

Research Briefing

4 July 2025

By Isabel Buchanan

Local elections 2025: Results and analysis



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Summary

On 1 May 2025, local elections were held in 23 of England's councils. Reform UK won the largest number of seats with 677, amounting to 41% of all seats up for election.

Labour remains the largest party in local government following the 2025 local elections. Continuing the recent trend first seen in 2023, councils are more likely to have 'no overall control' than be controlled by a political party.

Writing in the Local Government Chronicle, politics professors Colin Rallings and Michael Thrasher estimated that [Reform would have won the majority of seats if the elections had taken place in every part of the country](#), winning an estimated 32% of the vote.

Labour would have come second, with 19% - down from 34% in 2024. The Conservatives also saw a decline, falling to 18% from 27% in 2024. Lib Dems would have remained at 16%, the same as was estimated in 2024. Independents/ Other parties (including the Green party) were estimated at 15%, a decrease from 23% in 2024.

Data used in this briefing is taken mostly from the BBC and from professors Colin Rallings and Michael Thrasher.

Number of seats up for election

Local councillors are elected for four-year terms using the first past the post system. Across England, elections took place for 1,637 seats in 23 local authorities (1,731 including by-elections):

- 14 county councils
- Eight unitary authorities
- One metropolitan district

There were also elections for four combined authority mayors and two local council mayors.

Some elections planned for 2025 were postponed

Previously, all 21 county councils in England were due to hold local elections in the May 2025 election. In December 2024, the government gave councils the option to postpone local elections if this would “[help \[an\] area to deliver both reorganisation and devolution to the most ambitious timeframe](#)”. As a result, local elections were delayed in [nine county council areas](#).

Vote share of winning candidates is falling

This year’s local elections saw the lowest ever average winner’s share of the vote, at 40.7%. Academics Rallings and Thrasher report that there [were 75 candidates who were elected by winning less than 30% of the vote](#).

Summary of the results

Reform won 41% of seats up for election

Reform won 677 seats (41% of the total) and gained control of 10 councils. This is the first time that Reform (or the Brexit Party, as it was previously known) has controlled any councils in local government.

Labour won 6% of seats

Labour won 98 seats (6% of the total) and lost control of one council. Although not directly comparable, Labour won 28% of seats in 2021. The 2025 result is the lowest proportion of seats that Labour has won in over 20 years, down from a previous low of 7% in 2015.

Conservatives lost control of 16 councils

The Conservatives lost control of 16 councils in England. The Conservatives won 20% of seats up for election in this cycle, the second lowest proportion of seats that the party has won in the last 20 years.

Liberal Democrats won 23% of seats

The Liberal Democrats won control of three councils. The party won 23% of seats up for election, its highest result since 2008.

Green Party, Independents and no overall control

The Green Party won 5% of seats up for election, and the Green Party still controls 1 council (with a majority).

In England, 7 councils are controlled by independents or other parties, who won 6% of the vote.

Following the 2025 local elections, there were 161 councils in Great Britain with no overall control, which means that no party has a majority of councillors. This is 16 more than in 2024. Councils under no overall control make up the majority of councils in Great Britain.

1

Local elections in England

All areas of England are covered either by a unitary council, a metropolitan borough council, a London borough council or a county council. Unitary, metropolitan and London borough councils are all ‘single-tier’ councils.

Some areas of England have a ‘two-tier’ system, with upper-tier county councils covering multiple lower-tier district councils.

The number of councils and councillors in England has changed over time due to local authority restructures, which should be considered when comparing elections over the years, and the Boundary Commission administers a rolling programme of electoral reviews, which often changes ward boundaries.

Our Library paper on [Local government in England](#) explains the structure of local government in further detail, including the electoral system.

In total, there are 317 local authorities in England, made up of 5 different types:¹

- County councils
- District councils
- Unitary authorities
- Metropolitan districts
- London boroughs

These authorities are split up as follows:

Two-tier councils:

- 21 county councils
- 164 district councils

Single-tier councils:

- 62 unitary authorities
- 36 metropolitan districts
- 32 London boroughs

¹ Gov.uk, [local government structure and elections](#), 1 April 2023

- City of London
- Isles of Scilly

There are also elected mayors²:

- 10 combined authority mayors
- 1 mayor of London
- 15 local authority mayors

On 1 May 2025, elections were initially scheduled for:

- 21 upper-tier county councils
- one metropolitan district
- 10 unitary authorities (including nine unitary counties)
- four combined authority mayors in England
- two local authority mayors in England
- the Isles of Scilly (which has a unique governance structure)

Not all these elections went ahead as planned. Legislation came into effect on 4 March 2025 which postponed elections in nine local authorities until May 2026. These were the upper-tier county councils of:

- East Sussex
- Essex
- Hampshire
- Norfolk
- Suffolk
- Surrey
- West Sussex

and the unitary councils of:

- the Isle of Wight
- Thurrock

Most of the elections which took place in May 2025 were last held in 2021. However, some of the 2021 elections included those which had been postponed due to the covid-19 pandemic. It is therefore not possible to accurately compare this year's elections with another recent local election cycle.

² Electoral Commission, [Mayoral elections](#)

1.1

Electoral cycles in England

Local council members are elected for four-year terms using the first past the post system.

There are a variety of electoral cycles, with elections held in different years, so not all councillors are elected at the same time. In some authorities (including London boroughs and all county councils), elections for all councillors are held every four years. Others elect a proportion of members each year.

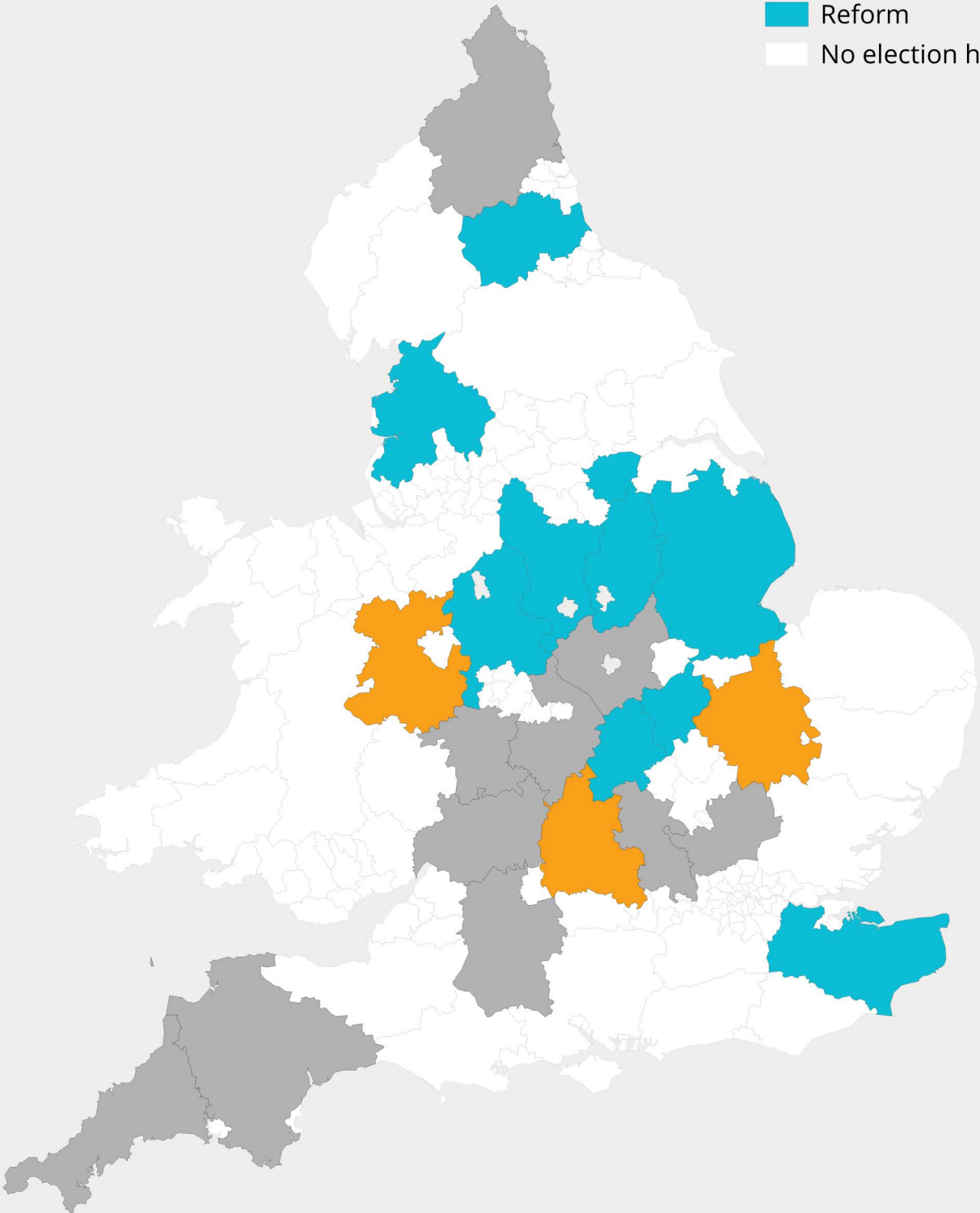
There are three methods of holding elections to local councils:

- Whole council: all councillors are elected once every four years in whole-council elections. Councils also elect all councillors after local authority boundary changes.
- Thirds: at each election, a third of the councillors are elected for four-year terms. Elections are held every year, except in years when there are county council elections in the rest of England.
- Halves: at each election, half the councillors are elected. Elections are held every two years.

Local Elections May 2025: Council control

Council control

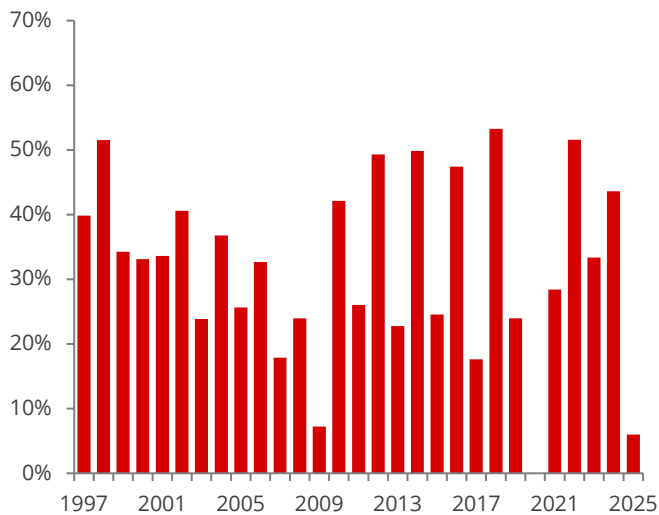
- Liberal Democrat
- No Overall Control
- Reform
- No election held



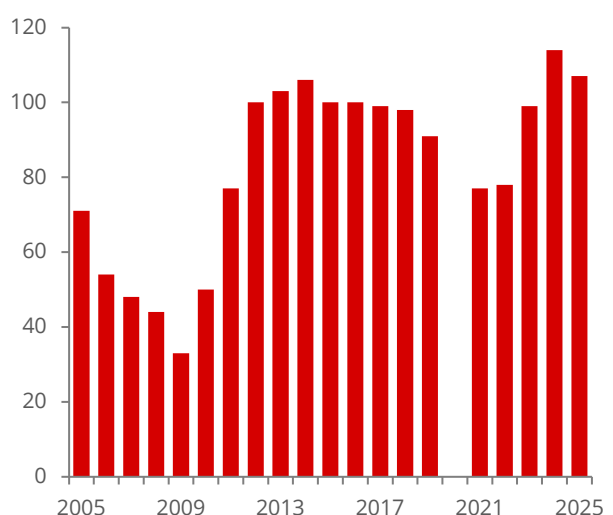
Labour

Labour won 6% of the seats up for election on 1 May 2025. This was a decrease from 28% in 2021 when similar seats were last up for election. The overall number of councils controlled by Labour decreased by 7 compared with immediately before the election; the party now controls 107 councils, the second highest number of councils it has controlled in recent history.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Councils controlled^b



Summary of Labour local election results

Election year	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Seats won	2,292	1,319	417	2,355	2,020	1,345	2,265	2,675	1,159	98
Unitary Councils	673	233	115	187	589	333	235	786	212	30
Metropolitan	634	664	43	723	472	571	594	724	505	12
London Boroughs	-	-	-	1,125	-	-	1,153	-	-	-
District Councils	985	422	-	320	959	269	283	1,165	442	-
County Councils	-	-	259	-	-	172	-	-	-	48
% of seats up for election won ^a	25%	47%	18%	53%	24%	28%	52%	33%	44%	6%
Councils controlled^b	100	100	99	98	91	77	78	99	114	107
Unitary Councils	18	19	20	20	15	11	10	20	23	22
Metropolitan	30	29	29	30	30	28	29	29	27	25
London Boroughs	20	21	21	21	21	21	21	21	21	21
District Councils	30	30	29	27	25	17	18	29	34	31
County Councils	2	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Net change in council control ^c	-6	0	-1	0	-6	-8	1	22	15	-7

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

b. Council control immediately following elections of stated year.

c. Net change compared to control immediately prior to election; figures not comparable with year-on-year changes to total number of councils controlled by party.

d. Figures for councils controlled and net change in councils controlled refer to those controlled by an absolute majority; minority controlled councils are excluded.

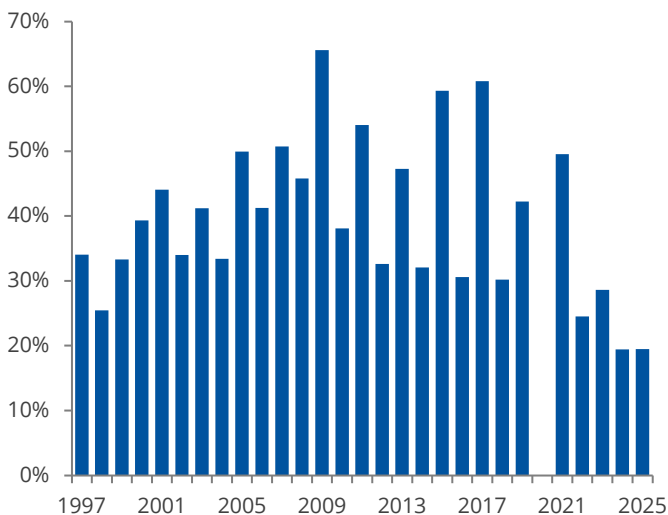
Grey fill indicates that there were no seats up for election in this category and year.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; 2017 - 2025 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Government Chronicle articles; BBC

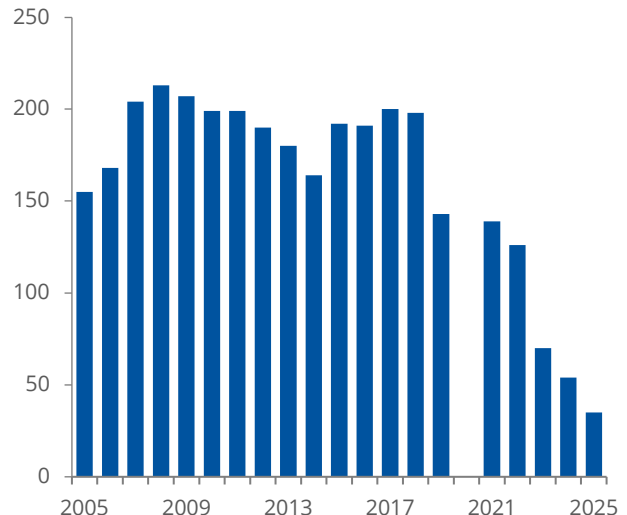
Conservative

The Conservatives won 20% of the seats up for election on 1 May 2025. This was a decrease from 50% in 2021, when similar seats were last up for election. The party controlled 19 fewer councils compared with immediately before the election. At 35, the total number of councils controlled is the lowest in more than 15 years, but this is partly due to local authority restructures meaning that there are fewer councils overall.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Councils controlled^b



Summary of Conservative local election results

Election year	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Seats won	5,540	851	1,440	1,332	3,559	2,345	1,075	2,296	515	319
Unitary Councils	941	138	231	108	698	648	184	497	89	101
Metropolitan	162	114	7	175	119	226	158	150	125	6
London Boroughs	-	-	-	511	-	-	401	-	-	-
District Councils	4,437	599	-	538	2,742	534	332	1,649	302	-
County Councils	-	-	1202	-	-	937	-	-	-	157
% of seats up for election won ^a	59%	31%	61%	30%	42%	50%	24%	29%	19%	20%
Councils controlled^b	192	191	200	198	143	139	126	70	54	35
Unitary Councils	19	21	22	23	16	22	19	12	7	1
Metropolitan	2	2	2	1	2	3	3	3	2	2
London Boroughs	9	9	9	7	7	7	5	5	5	5
District Councils	146	143	143	143	95	86	79	31	22	21
County Councils	16	16	24	24	23	21	20	19	18	6
Net change in council control ^c	28	-1	9	-2	-49	13	-13	-48	-16	-19

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

b. Council control immediately following elections of stated year.

c. Net change compared to control immediately prior to election; figures not comparable with year-on-year changes to total number of councils controlled by party.

d. Figures for councils controlled and net change in councils controlled refer to those controlled by an absolute majority; minority controlled councils are excluded.

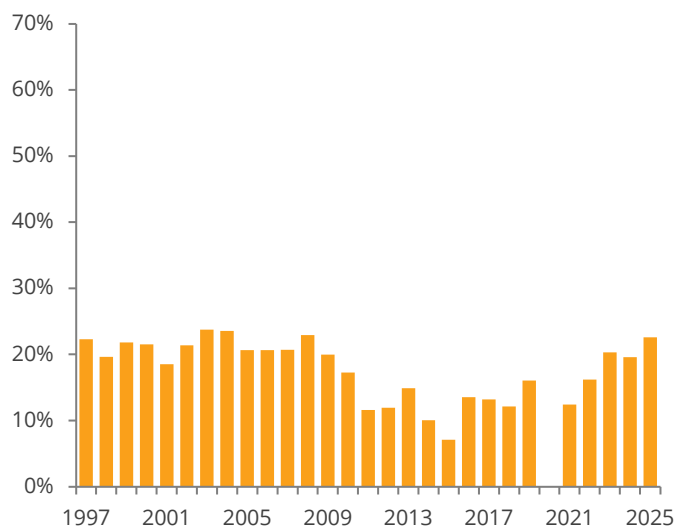
Grey fill indicates that there were no seats up for election in this category and year.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; 2017 - 2025 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Government Chronicle articles; BBC

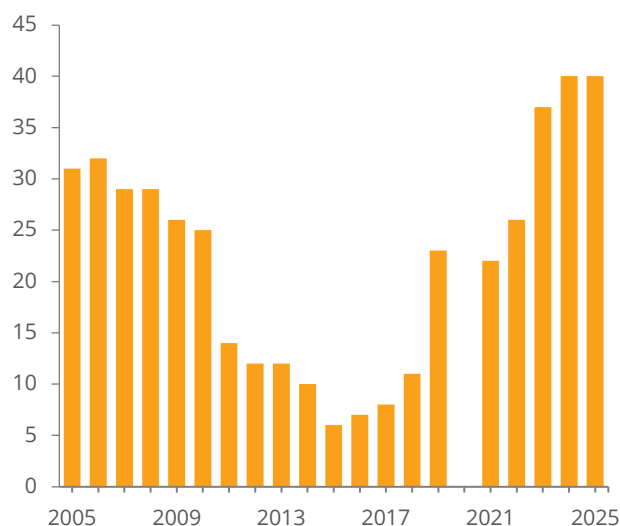
Liberal Democrat

The Liberal Democrats won 23% of all seats up for election. This was an increase of 11 percentage points since 2021, when similar seats were last up for election. Their total of councils controlled was 40, the same as immediately before the election. This is the most councils the Liberal Democrats have controlled in more than 15 years and continues the growth seen since a decade low of six councils controlled in 2015.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Councils controlled^b



Summary of Liberal Democrat local election results

Election year	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Seats won	661	377	313	537	1,351	588	712	1,628	522	370
Unitary Councils	123	54	88	48	287	146	158	355	119	109
Metropolitan	40	88	0	83	80	70	86	132	72	0
London Boroughs	-	-	-	152	-	-	177	-	-	-
District Councils	498	235	-	254	984	177	291	1,141	331	-
County Councils	-	-	225	-	-	195	-	-	-	208
% of seats up for election won ^a	7%	14%	13%	12%	16%	12%	16%	20%	19%	23%
Councils controlled^b	6	7	8	11	23	22	26	37	40	40
Unitary Councils	0	0	0	0	1	1	2	6	7	8
Metropolitan	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
London Boroughs	1	1	1	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
District Councils	5	6	7	8	19	18	20	28	30	27
County Councils	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	2
Net change in council control ^c	-4	1	0	4	12	1	4	12	3	0

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

b. Council control immediately following elections of stated year.

c. Net change compared to control immediately prior to election; figures not comparable with year-on-year changes to total number of councils controlled by party.

d. Figures for councils controlled and net change in councils controlled refer to those controlled by an absolute majority; minority controlled councils are excluded.

Grey fill indicates that there were no seats up for election in this category and year.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; 2017 - 2024 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Government Chronicle articles; BBC

Reform

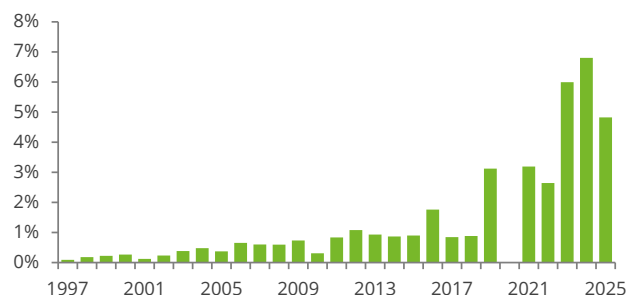
	2024	2025
Seats won	2	677
Unitary Councils	0	195
Metropolitan	0	38
London Boroughs	-	-
District Councils	2	-
County Councils	-	414
% of seats up for election won ^a	0%	41%
Councils controlled	0	10

Reform UK won 677 seats at the local elections on 1 May 2025, equivalent to 41% of all seats up for election. Reform also took control of ten councils, are the largest party in four other councils, and won two mayoral elections.

Green

The Green Party won 79 seats at the local elections on 1 May 2025, around 5% of all seats up for election. This is an increase of 2 percentage points from 2021. The Green party continues to control 1 council with a majority.

Percent of seats up for election won^a

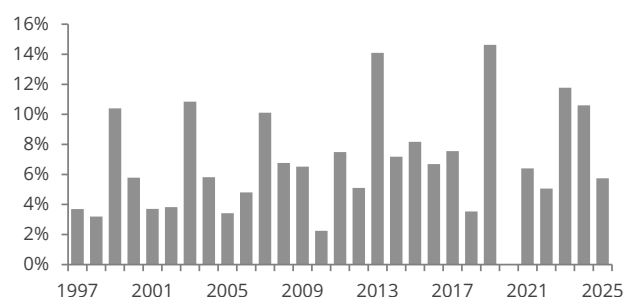


Election year	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Seats won	84	49	20	39	263	151	116	481	181	79
Unitary Councils	30	15	2	2	51	42	22	59	45	16
Metropolitan	7	12	0	18	24	27	36	49	32	0
London Boroughs	-	-	-	11	-	-	18	-	-	-
District Councils	47	22	-	8	188	39	40	373	104	-
County Councils	-	-	18	-	-	43	-	-	-	58
% of seats up for election won ^a	1%	2%	1%	1%	3%	3%	3%	6%	7%	5%

Other parties and independents

Other parties and independent candidates won 94 seats in the local elections on 1 May 2025, around 5% of the seats up for election. This was a significant decrease compared to some previous years, for example, when the highest proportion of seats won by other parties and independents was 15% in 2019. In England, 7 councils are controlled by other parties/ independents.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Election year	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Seats won	763	186	179	156	1,232	303	222	945	280	94
Unitary Councils	145	28	91	14	259	115	34	208	39	62
Metropolitan	17	43	5	25	39	28	40	54	78	0
London Boroughs	-	-	-	34	-	-	59	-	-	-
District Councils	601	115	-	77	934	78	89	683	163	-
County Councils	-	-	83	-	-	82	-	-	-	32
% of seats up for election won ^a	8%	7%	8%	4%	15%	6%	5%	12%	11%	5%

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

Grey fill indicates that there were no seats up for election in this category and year.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; 2017 - 2024 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Government Chronicle articles; BBC

2

Post-election council control and councillors

2.1

England: Labour remains the largest party in local government, but Reform UK made significant gains

The table below summarises council composition and control for all local authorities in England immediately following the local elections held on 1 May 2025. This includes councils where elections were not held.

Notably, there are currently more councils under no overall control, meaning they have no majority of councillors from a single party, than the number of councils controlled by any one party.

The Labour Party holds the greatest share of seats and councils in England, holding 34% of seats and controlling 31% of councils.

The Conservatives are the second largest party in local government in England, holding 26% of seats and controlling 11% of councils.

The Liberal Democrats are the third largest party, holding 19% of seats and controlling 13% of councils in England.

The Green Party has 5% of seats and maintained majority control of Mid Suffolk council.

Reform UK now holds 5% of seats and controls 3% of councils. The party gained control of 10 councils, and also became the largest party in four additional councils where no party holds overall control. Additionally, Reform UK secured two new directly elected mayors in Greater Lincolnshire and Hull and East Yorkshire.

Other parties and Independents hold 12% of seats and control 2% of councils.

The results represent a significant shift in local government control compared with the last local elections in 2024.

English post-election council composition: May 2025							
Councillors	REF	LAB	CON	LD	GRN	Other	NOC
Number of seats							
London boroughs	0	1,108	395	182	23	109	-
Counties	421	89	470	287	81	84	-
Metropolitan boroughs	44	1,449	337	243	105	213	-
Districts	63	1,606	2,030	1,578	492	1,023	-
Unitary authorities	248	1,150	885	760	144	441	-
England	776	5,402	4,117	3,050	845	1,870	-
Percent							
London boroughs	0%	61%	22%	10%	1%	6%	-
Counties	29%	6%	33%	20%	6%	6%	-
Metropolitan boroughs	2%	61%	14%	10%	4%	9%	-
Districts	1%	24%	30%	23%	7%	15%	-
Unitary authorities	7%	32%	24%	21%	4%	12%	-
England	5%	34%	26%	19%	5%	12%	-
Councils controlled	REF	LAB	CON	LD	GRN	Other	NOC
Number							
London boroughs	0	21	5	3	0	2	1
Counties	6	0	6	2	0	0	7
Metropolitan boroughs	1	25	2	0	0	0	8
Districts	0	31	21	27	1	5	79
Unitary authorities	3	22	1	8	0	0	28
England	10	99	35	40	1	7	123
Percent							
London boroughs	0%	66%	16%	9%	0%	6%	3%
Counties	29%	0%	29%	10%	0%	0%	33%
Metropolitan boroughs	3%	69%	6%	0%	0%	0%	22%
Districts	0%	19%	13%	16%	1%	3%	48%
Unitary authorities	5%	35%	2%	13%	0%	0%	45%
England	3%	31%	11%	13%	0%	2%	39%

Source: Rallings and Thrasher, Local Government Chronicle, [How Reform delivered shock to two-party system](#).

Note: 'NOC' stands for 'No overall control'. This means that no single party has enough seats to hold a majority on the council. The above chart reflects composition immediately following the election – councillor and seat numbers may have since changed.

The following table looks at council composition and control for all local authorities in England immediately following elections by year (generally held on the first Thursday of May). As above, this includes those where elections were not held.

English council control immediately after local elections										
	Number					Percent				
	CON	LAB	LD	OTH	NOC	CON	LAB	LD	OTH	NOC
2005	155	71	31	7	122	40%	18%	8%	2%	32%
2006	168	54	32	5	127	44%	14%	8%	1%	33%
2007	204	48	29	5	100	53%	12%	8%	1%	26%
2008	213	44	29	5	95	55%	11%	8%	1%	25%
2009	207	33	26	4	81	59%	9%	7%	1%	23%
2010	199	50	25	4	73	57%	14%	7%	1%	21%
2011	199	77	14	1	60	57%	22%	4%	0%	17%
2012	190	100	12	1	48	54%	28%	3%	0%	14%
2013	180	103	12	1	55	51%	29%	3%	0%	16%
2014	164	106	10	1	70	47%	30%	3%	0%	20%
2015	192	100	6	2	51	55%	28%	2%	1%	15%
2016	191	100	7	1	52	54%	28%	2%	0%	15%
2017	200	99	8	2	42	57%	28%	2%	1%	12%
2018	198	98	11	1	43	56%	28%	3%	0%	12%
2019	143	91	23	5	79	42%	27%	7%	1%	23%
2020	(no local elections in this year because of the Covid-19 pandemic)									
2021	139	77	22	5	88	41%	23%	7%	2%	27%
2022	126	78	26	6	95	38%	24%	8%	2%	29%
2023	70	99	37	4	103	22%	32%	12%	1%	33%
2024	54	105	40	7	109	17%	33%	13%	2%	35%
2025	35	99	40	18	123	11%	31%	13%	6%	39%

Source: Rallings and Thrasher, Local Elections Handbooks 2005-2016 and Local Government Chronicle articles; House of Commons Library.

Note: Reform UK has been included in 'Other' in the above table for 2025 due to having no previous council control data.

Results for 2022 include the new councils in North Yorkshire and Somerset but do not include the new unitary authorities of Cumberland and Westmorland and Furness.

The Conservatives control 104 fewer councils than in 2021 (the closest comparable year for local elections). Labour controls 22 more councils than in 2021. The Liberal Democrats control 40 councils, 18 more than in 2021. This is the party's highest return (the same as in 2024).

It should be noted that in 2025, the 'Other' category includes Reform UK, which does not have any previous council control history to include in this table. This therefore means that the 'Other' category cannot be strictly compared with previous years, and is higher than in previous years due to the substantial gains made by Reform. 'Other' results not including Reform would have given 'Other' approximately 3% of the overall number of councils. This would still be the highest result for this category in the last 20 years.

In the recent past, the Conservatives typically controlled approximately twice as many councils as Labour (for example, 56% compared with 28% in 2018). Since 2019, this pattern has changed, with Labour controlling 24% of councils and the Conservatives controlling 38% in 2022. This trend has since swung the other way, with Labour now controlling 31% of councils and the Conservatives controlling 11%.

Continuing a trend observed since 2023, there were more councils where no party had an overall majority ('no overall control') than there were councils controlled by a single party. 123 councils had 'no overall control' following the May elections, making up 39% of all councils. The proportion of councils falling under no overall control has been steadily increasing since 2023. However, as the table below shows, 'no overall control' is a more common outcome in some types of councils (districts and unitary authorities) than others (London and metropolitan boroughs, and county councils).

English council control immediately after local elections

	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
London boroughs																
CON	14	11	11	11	11	9	9	9	9	7	7	7	5	5	5	5
LAB	7	17	17	17	17	20	20	21	21	21	21	21	21	21	21	21
LD	3	2	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	2
NOC	8	2	2	2	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	1	2	2	2	1
Counties																
CON	26	26	26	26	16	16	16	16	24	24	23	21	20	19	18	6
LAB	0	0	0	0	2	2	2	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
LD	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	2
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	6
NOC	1	1	1	1	9	9	9	10	3	3	3	3	3	2	3	7
Metropolitan boroughs																
CON	6	3	3	2	2	2	2	2	2	1	2	3	3	3	2	2
LAB	12	16	24	29	29	30	30	29	29	30	30	28	29	29	27	25
LD	5	2	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1
NOC	13	15	9	5	5	4	4	5	5	5	4	5	4	4	7	8
Districts																
CON	137	135	136	131	131	119	146	143	143	143	95	86	79	31	22	21
LAB	5	7	19	31	32	33	30	30	29	27	25	17	12	29	34	31
LD	15	18	11	9	9	9	5	6	7	8	19	18	23	28	30	27
OTH	4	4	1	1	1	1	2	1	2	1	5	5	6	4	6	6
NOC	40	37	34	29	28	39	18	21	20	22	48	55	61	71	72	79
Unitary authorities																
CON	24	24	23	20	20	18	19	21	22	23	16	22	22	12	7	1
LAB	9	10	17	23	23	21	18	19	20	20	15	11	9	20	23	22
LD	3	3	1	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	4	6	7	8
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	3
NOC	19	18	14	11	11	16	18	15	13	12	23	24	27	24	25	28

Source: Rallings and Thrasher, Local Elections Handbooks 2005-2016 and Local Government Chronicle articles.

Note: Reform UK has been included in 'Other' in the above table for 2025 due to having no previous local election data.

This table shows that, Labour has typically performed strongly in London and metropolitan councils, while the Conservatives have dominated in county councils.

The Conservatives also previously controlled most district councils, but its position weakened from 2019 onwards, and 'no overall control' is now the most likely outcome in district councils.

In unitary authorities, the Conservatives' lead weakened from 2011 onwards, with Labour and the Conservatives alternating as the biggest party since then. Labour have been the largest political party in unitary authorities since 2022. However, since 2019, both parties have controlled fewer unitary councils than have been under no overall control.

2.2

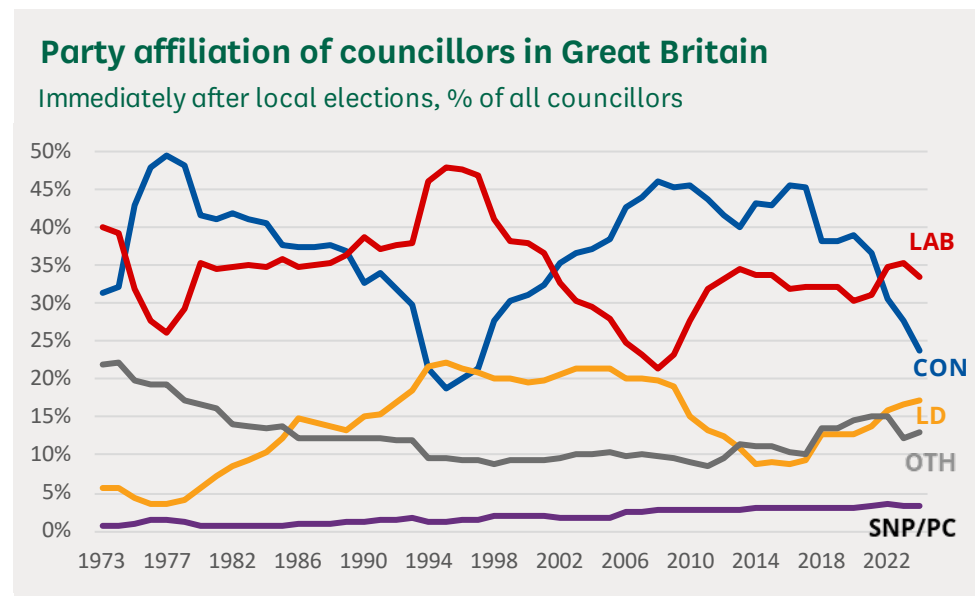
Councillors by party in Great Britain

The chart below shows the number of councillors by party in Great Britain between 1973 and 2025.

In total, there are currently 18,520 councillors in Great Britain. This is not a fixed number, and local authority restructures and ward boundary reviews means this figure changes over time.

Following the elections in May 2025, Labour has the most councillors in Great Britain (6,182).

They are followed by the Conservatives (4,417), and then the Lib Dems (3,200). Reform UK now have 791 councillors.



Source: Rallings and Thrasher, Local Elections Handbooks 2005-2016 and Local Government Chronicle articles.

Note: Reform UK **have** been included in the 'others' line in the above graph.

3

England: Mayoral elections

There were mayoral elections in six areas of England on 1 May 2025. Four of these were elections for the mayoralties of combined authorities (known as ‘metro-mayors’).³ The other two were council mayoral elections.

Combined authority mayoral election results

01 May 2025

Cambridgeshire & Peterborough				Greater Lincolnshire			
CON gain from LAB				REF gain			
Paul Bristow	CON	60,243	28.4%	Andrea Jenkyns	REF	104,133	42.0%
Ryan Coogan	REF	49,647	23.4%	Rob Waltham	CON	64,585	26.1%
Anna Smith	LAB	42,671	20.1%	Jason Stockwood	LAB	30,384	12.3%
Lorna Dupré	LD	41,611	19.6%	Marianne Overton	OTH	19,911	8.0%
Bob Ensich	GRN	18,255	8.6%	Sally Horscroft	GRN	15,040	6.1%
				Trevor Young	LD	13,728	5.5%
Electorate		645,779		Electorate		828,613	
Turnout		32.9%		Turnout		29.9%	
Hull & East Yorkshire				West of England			
REF gain				LAB hold			
Luke Campbell	REF	48,491	35.8%	Helen Godwin	LAB	51,197	25.0%
Mike Ross	LD	37,510	27.7%	Arron Banks	REF	45,252	22.1%
Anne Handley	CON	21,393	15.8%	Mary Page	GRN	41,094	20.0%
Margaret Pinder	LAB	18,568	13.7%	Steve Smith	CON	34,092	16.6%
Kerry Harrison	GRN	5,049	3.7%	Oli Henman	LD	28,711	14.0%
Rowan Halstead	YRKS	4,372	3.2%	Ian Scott	IND	4,682	2.3%
Electorate		454,462		Electorate		682,951	
Turnout		29.8%		Turnout		30.0%	

Source: East Cambridgeshire council, [Mayoral election 2025 results](#); Greater Lincolnshire CCA, [Greater Lincolnshire Mayor elected](#); East Riding of Yorkshire council, [Results of the Mayoral election](#); West of England CA, [Election Results 2025](#)

As shown in the table above, two of the four combined authority mayoral elections were won by a Reform UK candidate. These were Greater Lincolnshire (Andrea Jenkyns) and Hull and East Yorkshire (Luke Campbell). Turnout was just under 30% for both elections. Both of these were new mayoralties.

³ More information on metro-mayors can be found in the Commons library briefing: [Devolution to local government in England](#)

In Cambridgeshire and Peterborough the Conservative candidate, Paul Bristow, was elected mayor. This was the first Cambridgeshire and Peterborough mayoral election to use the first past the post system.

In the West of England, Labour's Helen Godwin was elected with 25% of the vote. This was the first West of England mayoral election to use the first past the post system.

Council mayoral election results							
01 May 2025							
Doncaster		LAB hold		North Tyneside		LAB hold	
Ros Jones	LAB	23,805	32.6%	Karen Clark	LAB	16,230	30.2%
Alexander Jones	REF	23,107	31.6%	John Falkenstein	REF	15,786	29.4%
Nick Fletcher	CON	18,982	26.0%	Liam Bones	CON	11,017	20.5%
Julie Buckley	GRN	2,449	3.4%	Chloe-Louise Reilly	GRN	3,980	7.4%
Andrew Walmsley	YRKS	1,164	1.6%	John Appleby	LD	3,453	6.4%
David Bettney	SDP	929	1.3%	Cath Davis	IND	1,780	3.3%
Mihai Melenciuc	LD	895	1.2%	Martin Uren	IND	1,460	2.7%
Frank Calladine	OTH	448	0.6%				
Ahsan Jamil	WPB	434	0.6%	Electorate		159,717	
Andy Hiles	TUSC	393	0.5%	Turnout		33.6%	
Richie Vallance	IND	245	0.3%				
Doug Wright	IND	157	0.2%				
Electorate		227,495					
Turnout		32.1%					

Source: Doncaster council, [Mayoral election results 2025](#); North Tyneside council, [Mayoral election results](#)

Labour won both council mayoral elections, as shown in the table above.

In Doncaster, Ros Jones was elected with 32.6% of the vote and a winning margin of just under 1%, or 698 votes. The turnout was 32.1%.

Karen Clark became mayor in North Tyneside with 30.2% of the vote and a winning margin of 0.8%, or 444 votes. The turnout was 33.6%.

First past the post system

The May 2025 mayoral elections were some of the first mayoral elections to use the first past the post system, rather than the supplementary vote system. This was changed following the introduction of the Elections Act 2022, with the first mayoral elections to use first past the post taking place in May 2023.⁴

⁴ Electoral Commission, [Changes to the voting system for mayoral and PCC elections](#), 2 February 2023

4

National share of the vote

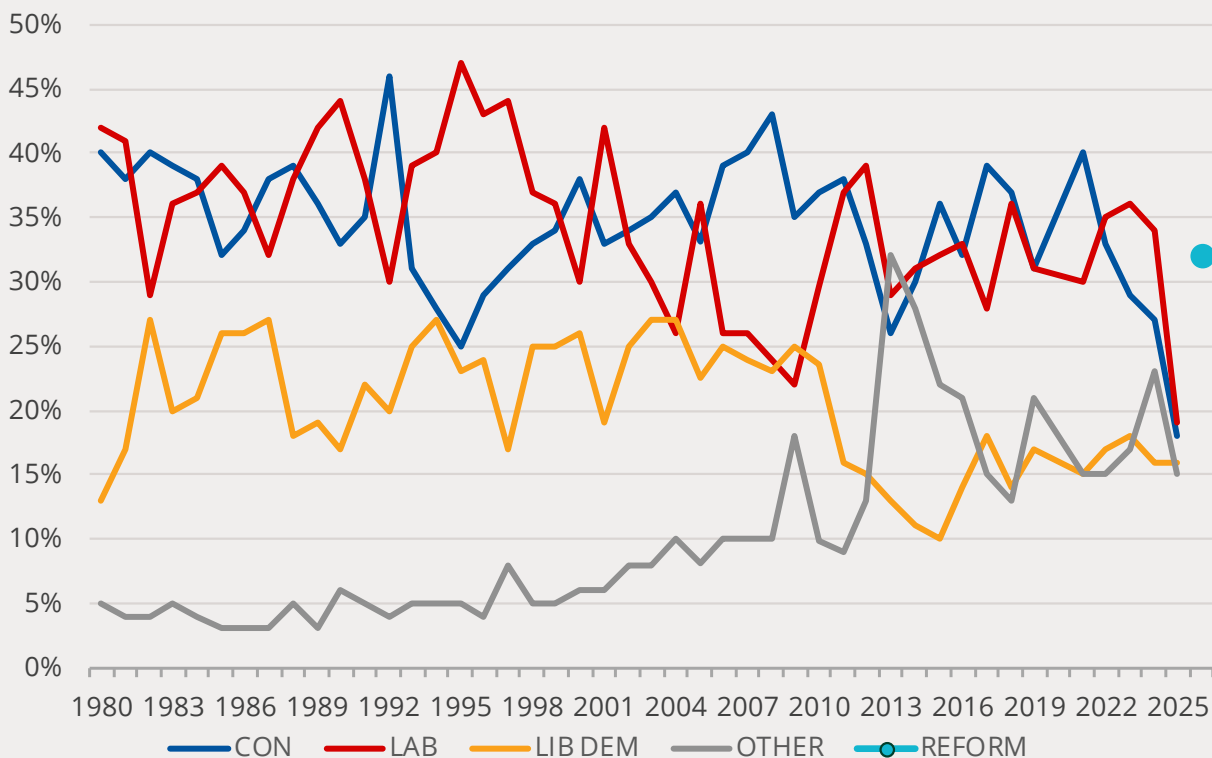
Because local elections are not held in all local authorities at the same time, it's difficult to get an overview of how much support political parties attract across Great Britain in the years between general elections.

The academics Colin Rallings and Michael Thrasher overcome this by using the results of local elections to estimate how the major parties would have fared had the elections of that year taken place throughout Great Britain. Rallings and Thrasher's national equivalent share of the vote (NEV) is a widely used estimate of where political parties stand nationally based on voting in local elections.

The chart below shows how Reform, the Conservatives, Labour, Liberal Democrats and other parties would have performed if local elections had taken place across Great Britain.

Estimated NEV at local elections: Great Britain

% share of total estimated vote



Source: Rallings and Thrasher, Local Elections Handbook, various years; Rallings and Thrasher, Local Government Chronicle, [How Reform delivered shock to two-party system](#).

Notes: Please note that Reform have been separated from 'other' in the above graph, so as not to overly distort the 'other' category, as Reform would have won the majority of the vote had elections been held across all of Great Britain.

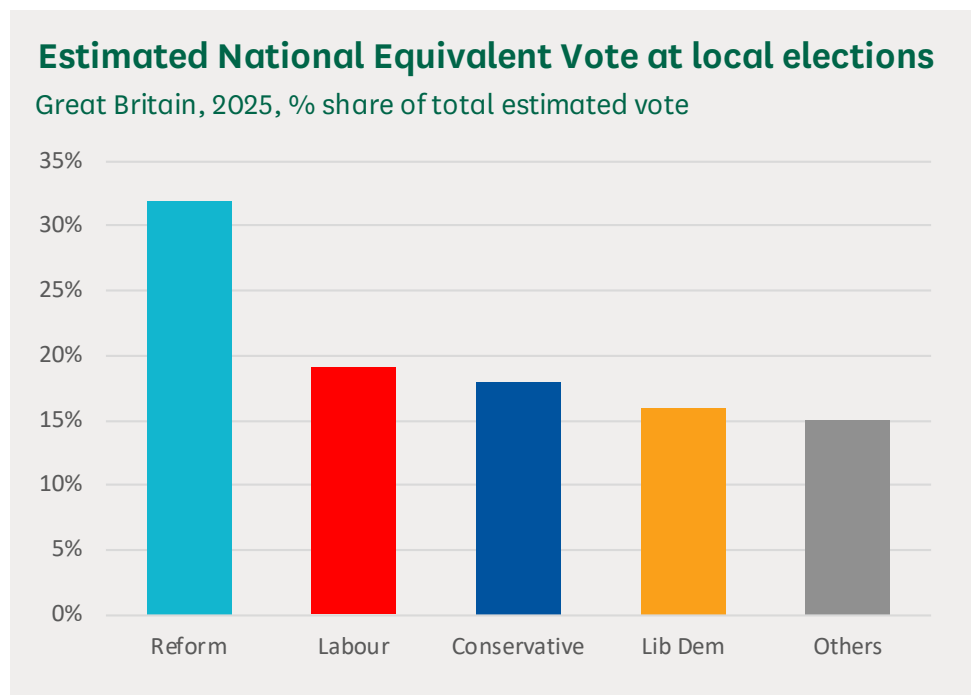
It's estimated that Reform UK would have won 32% of the vote if local elections had been held across all of Great Britain in 2025 (the 'national estimated vote'). This was over 10 percentage points higher than any other party.

Labour had an estimated 19% of the national vote share, a drop of 15 percentage points from 34% in 2024, and a sharp turn from the steady increase the party had been experiencing since 2021.

The Conservatives had an estimated 18% of the national vote share. This was a decrease from 27% in 2024, and continued a decline from the decade high of 40% in 2021.

The Liberal Democrats stayed at 16%. The 'Others' category decreased to 15%, down from 23% in 2024. It should be noted that Rallings and Thrasher included Reform in their calculations for the 'other' category in 2024, however separated Reform out from 'others' for the 2025 estimates.

The graph below shows the estimated national equivalent vote for 2025 only in more detail.



Source: Rallings and Thrasher, Local Elections Handbook, various years; Rallings and Thrasher, Local Government Chronicle, [How Reform delivered shock to two-party system](#).

5

About the data

There is no official body collecting and publishing local election results.

The academics Colin Rallings and Michael Thrasher have compiled [Local Elections Handbooks](#) each year since 1985 (together with the House of Commons Library since 2021). Links to these are also provided below. Historical data quoted in this briefing is mostly derived from these handbooks. More recent data on council control and councillor numbers comes from Rallings and Thrasher's May articles in The Sunday Times and the Local Government Chronicle.

Data on the 2025 local election results comes from the BBC, cross-checked with local authorities where necessary.

Findings presented in this briefing may in some cases differ from analysis available elsewhere because of different definitions or reference points used. Data here reflects council control and seat control immediately after the election. Some of these figures may have already changed since the election, for example due to resignations, and these changes are not reflected in this briefing.

Local election handbooks:

- [2024 Local Elections Handbook and dataset](#)
- [2023 Local Elections Handbook and dataset](#)
- [2022 Local Elections Handbook and dataset](#)
- [2021 Local Elections Handbook and dataset](#)

5.1

How are local election results analysed?

Local election results are commonly analysed in two ways:

- The total number of councils controlled and the total number of councillors a party has at a given time, usually immediately following elections
- The number of councils or seats won and lost at any given round of elections. This measures net change, comparing the number of councils or seats won and lost at an election with the situation immediately before that election

The net change figures will not necessarily match the annual totals because parties' total number of councillors and councils controlled are subject to change over the course of the year (for example because of by-elections or councillors changing party affiliation).

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